Before Your First Care Conversation

Fifteen questions for Mom, the family and the people who already help, sorted by who can answer them, with room to write what they say.

Your sister knows the appointment schedule. The neighbor knows about the mail. Mom knows the rest. Each of them holds part of how her week works, and nobody has asked them all the same questions.

This guide sorts the questions by who can answer them and leaves room under each for what they say. It doesn't answer them and doesn't say which matters most. Take them a few at a time, whenever a visit or a phone call gives you the opening.

Mom

The best source on Mom's week is Mom. Ask on an ordinary afternoon, and write her answers the way she says them.

1. Would you walk me through an ordinary week, from Monday to Sunday?

2. What do your mornings, daytimes, evenings and nights usually look like?

3. Who do you see or hear from in a usual week, and what does each of them do?

4. Are there notes or lists, such as what was written down at an appointment, that you'd be happy for us to keep with the family's notes?

5. When we've written this down, would you read it and tell us what we got wrong?

The person who does the most for her

Whoever in the family has the largest part in Mom's week right now. It might be the sister who drives her to appointments.

1. What do you do for Mom in a usual week, including the things that take five minutes?

2. Which of those are getting harder to keep up?

3. Which parts of her daily routine do you know that the rest of us don't?

Brothers, sisters and other relatives

1. Which part of Mom's week do you see, and how would you describe it in a few lines?

2. What do you do for her, and how often?

3. What do you think we should get written down while there's time?

The neighbors and friends who already help

The neighbor who brings in the mail, the friend who phones. Let Mom know you're asking.

1. What do you do for Mom, and on which days?

2. What's the best number to reach you on, and may we add it to the family's list?

Her doctor's office

A question about paperwork, not about her health. Whether to go ahead is Mom's choice.

1. If Mom would like you to be able to speak with one of us, what does she need to do?

A care consultant

Someone whose work starts with a family interview about the current arrangement and what a typical day looks like.

1. Here is the picture we've written down. What else would you want to know about how things work today?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions, put them in order of importance, or say what any answer means. What Mom and the others tell you is the family's picture, in their own words.

Ready for the next step?

You know which questions to ask and who can answer each. The care interview gives the answers somewhere to go: it asks about Mom's situation area by area and turns what you've learned into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›